himself noted, ‘Truth has an eternal title to our confession, though we are sure to be the sufferers by it.’[9]

In fact, slowly but surely we are moving into the direction not only of a more fulsome apology in place of a simple expression of words but also of demonstrable acts of atonement. Perhaps the way to do it has been shown most recently by the Archbishop of Canterbury Justin Welby. He did not apologize. But he achieved something more than what a bare apology would have done. On 10 September 2019, he physically prostrated himself before the Jallianwala Bagh memorial in Amritsar, lying level on the ground before it, as a mark of respect for the victims of the 1919 massacre, declaring that he was ashamed and sorry that such an incident took place. His words are a testament to the power of words in the quest for atonement and reconciliation: ‘I have no status to apologise on behalf of the UK, its government or its history,’ he said, ‘but I am personally very sorry for this terrible atrocity.’ He added, ‘Coming here arouses a sense of profound shame at what happened in this place. It is one of a number of deep stains on British history. The pain and grief that has transcended the generations since must never be dismissed or denied.’

His Facebook post after the visit went further: ‘When there is something on the scale and horror of this massacre, and done so many years ago, words can be cheaply bandied around, as if a simple apology would ever be enough.’[10] His words on the day provide a practical example of how atonement is to be undertaken, for he lamented the misuse of power when he described how ‘[t]he souls of those who were killed or wounded, of the bereaved, cry out to us from these stones and warn us about power and the misuse of power’. He went on to say, ‘I cannot speak for the British government . . . but I can speak in the name of Christ and say this is a place of both sin and redemption, because you have remembered what they have done and their names will live, their memory will live before God. And I am so ashamed and sorry for the impact of this crime committed here.’

His words showed more than a determined stride towards real reconciliation when he said, ‘Learning of what happened, I recognise the sins of my British colonial history, the ideology that too often subjugated